Anxiety with Tic Tacs

From Drums, Girls and Dangerous Pie

By Jordan Sonnenblick

I don't know about any of you, but when I'm nervous about something, I tend to think about it all day, unless I come up with a complicated mental trick to distract me. And even then, I'm still actually thinking about the thing by NOT thinking about it, if that makes any sense. It's like, if someone came up to you and said, "All right, now whatever you do, DON'T think of the color red." You'd try to picture a different color, or repeat a recipe over and over in your head, or count to a hundred and fifty-nine, but somewhere in the back of your mind, you'd be going, "Yellow. . . orange. . . red. . . DOH! Three eggs, separated. . . five slices American Cheese. . . red. . . DANG! One hundred seventeen. . . one hundred eighteen. . . look at Renee's red lipstick. . . ARGHH!"

INTRODUCTION

In this excerpt from Drums, Girls and Dangerous Pie . . . Steven relates the difficulty he has on a day that will always hold significance in his life. A day much like any other . . . a day when he was supposed to be watching his younger brother Jeffrey and making him breakfast . But accidents do happen and this particular morning Jeffrey had climbed up on a stool to watch the breakfast making activities. A slip, a fall, a rush of blood. It all happened so quickly. And as Steven was sent off to school, his mother took Jeffrey to the hospital just to make sure everything was OK. Anxiety with Tic Tacs by Jordan Sonnenblick.

And that's how my October 7th went. I worked mightily to think about anything other than Jeffrey's gushing nose, but the distractions were truly pointless. In homeroom, after I figured out that my breath was going to present a challenge, I looked in the pocket of my Trapper Keeper for my box of Tic Tacs, and found that it was about three-quarters full. I quickly popped in a Tic Tac (orange, which I'm not even sure helps your breath anyway), and ran off to first period -Miss Palma's class. I did all the usual take-out-your -notebook stuff, but then became lost in my own little "Don't Think About Jeffrey" world.

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I used a trick that is pretty powerful for me; I came up with a really complex math problem to solve in my head:

"A boy has a box of forty Tic Tacs, and the box is three quarters full. The Tic Tacs need to last through an entire school day and a bus ride home. The school day has seven periods. Each period is forty-four minutes long, with three minutes for passing between classes. Additionally, there is a twenty-two minute lunch period, and a four-minute afternoon homeroom period. The bus ride takes fifteen minutes, including the wait for the bus, boarding, and the actual time-in-transit. If the boy wants to make his Tic Tacs last until he arrives at home, how many minutes must he wait between Tic Tacs?"

So while everybody else was writing whatever the day's journal was supposed to be, I was agonizing over the details of this math problem: "OK, there are HOW many three minute passing times? Seven, not counting the one before lunch. So eight. Eight times three is twenty-four. Plus the time in class, which is forty-four minutes times seven. . . ummm . . . OK, that's three hundred and eight minutes right there. And lunch is another twenty-two minutes, plus the bus is, like fifteen minutes. . . WAIT! Do I have to eat Tic Tacs during class? Who cares about my breath when I'm alone at my desk? But there IS group work in some. . ."

Steven! Would you like to read your journal entry aloud?

No, thank you, Miss Palma.

Steven, I know I phrased that as a question, but it was really a command.

Yes, but mine….well, it's private.

PRIVATE, Steven? (Again with the capital letters!)

Yes, private.

Through my haze of math and memory, I gradually noticed that the class was cracking up.

Steven, I respect privacy but how private can your thoughts on this subject BE?

Well. . . I . . .

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As it turns out, the topic was, "Should Foreign Languages Be Taught in Middle School?"

Things like that happened all day. After math, just as I popped in my seventh Tic Tac, Renee Albert said to me, *Steven, you are, like, out of, it today. Are you recovering from some kind of traumatic head injury, or something?*

Well, sort of.

Are you sort of remembering or faking some sort of an injury?

Both. I fell off a stool this morning and. . .

Oh, sorry, Stephen. I have to go talk to Jenna and Steph. Wait upl

While Renee was attractively speed-walking away, Annette suddenly appeared next to me. It wasn't the first time I noticed this - how Renee kind of swished around in a cloud of perfume, and Annette just popped up like some spastic hand-puppet.

Stephen, I heard about Jeffery, what happened? Annette sometimes watches Jeffrey on weekends.

Well, his, head hit the counter in the kitchen, and it started bleeding.

A lot?

Yeah. My mom is going to the hospital with him. They went to the emergency room. And now I'm going to be in trouble but I didn't even do …

Is he okay? I bet he's really scared!

I don't know.

And the bell rang, which meant I'd be late to social studies, and Annette would be late to science. While Annette ran away down the empty hall it suddenly hit me that I hadn't even thought about how Jeffrey was feeling about this. And I didn't really want to think too hard about it, because I knew he'd be terrified. Plus, now I had to go get a late pass, which probably meant I'd get a detention. So Jeffrey was getting me in trouble again, as usual.

The high point of my day was my drum lesson. We have this thing called "Opportunity Period," or "O.P." It's the last period of the day, and if you don't owe work in any of your

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classes, or need tutoring, or have detention, you get to do fun stuff. Most of the kids like to go to gym during O.P. -the track, the weight room, and the pool are all open, and you can play basketball or volleyball, too. But some go to art or choir. And, of course, every chance I get, I go to the band room. A few times a week. I used to get individual lessons on the drum set with the band teacher, Mr. Watras, during O.P. On this particular day, Mr. W. got called to the office for something, so I had about fifteen minutes to just play drums, with nobody else around. I started out with some simple beats. When my hands and feet started to loosen up, I switched over to this really complicated Latin rhythm I'd been working on. It took a lot of concentration to keep all four limbs moving independently of each other, which was perfect. It meant I wasn't thinking about Jeffery's fall, or late passes, or even Renee Albert. I was just playing.

After keeping the beat going for five minutes or so, I burst into a big solo. I always think of it that way: "Here comes Steven, bursting into his Big Solo. Watch those hands-they're too quick to follow. Holy cow, this kid is a magician!" Like there's a Monday Night Football commentator standing over my left shoulder. Anyway, I really was flying. I started with both hands doing a kind of shuffled march on the snare drum, pretty quietly. As I gradually got louder, I started flicking little quick shots at the high toms. Then I threw in some big "bombs" with my bass drum foot. Soon, I had an incredibly fast paradiddle going between my left hand and my right foot, while my left foot was keeping time on the high-hat cymbals and my right hand was going back and forth between the ride cymbal and the floor tom.

The door opened, and I opened my eyes and looked up (I never open my eyes when I'm practicing by myself-my private teacher always used to say if you don't know where the drums are, you're probably playing the wrong instrument). Mr. W was back. Behind him, I could see a few kids I didn't know-probably sixth graders on their way somewhere -looking in. They started clapping when I looked their way, which was pretty cool. I hadn't been showing off on purpose, but I can't say I minded the applause. I stood up and took a quick

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bow for them. Mr. W. smiled and complimented me on my "showmanship." That's yet another cool thing about music: if you show off in sports you're a "hot dog," if you show off in class, you're a "brainiac," but if you show off in drumming, people love it.

Mr. W. told me that my Latin rhythm was sounding a little stiff, and put on a CD for me to listen to. It was this old jazz album by Dizzy Gillespie.

This should help you out. It's by a cat named Dizzy.

Yes, he said "cat." Music teachers have their own lingo.

Dizzy Gillespie, the trumpet player, right? My grandfather once told me about him.

The tune's called "Cubano Be, Cubano Bop."

When the tune came on, I couldn't believe it. There were probably about five drummers on the track, and they were going crazy! The conga drum player was especially wild, playing insane fill-ins all over the place. At the same time, the trumpets were blasting like a herd of elephants, with Dizzy's horn flying high above everything else. Then, just when it seemed there couldn't possibly be any way to get more energy into the music, everyone stopped playing except the conga guy, and a man's voice started chanting in what sounded like Spanish. The chant got faster and faster, the congas got louder and louder, a whole chorus of men came in, shouting "Cubano be, Cubano bop" over and over, and the horns all roared back to life. Then, with one last explosion from the conga player, the song was over.

Could you feel that, Pez?

Mr. W. is the conductor of the All-City High School Jazz Band, which is how I got in. He knew that the nickname "Peasant" bugged me, so one day he started calling me "Pez" for short, which was much better.

Could I feel it? That's just the coolest thing I've ever heard in my life!

Good. I hope that later in the month you can get that conga part down.

What do you mean?

Well, I've decided that the spring concert is going to be all Latin and this song is going

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to be the finale! Would you like to play conga on it?

Of course, I was dying to play that part, but Mr. W is one of those rare teachers who can actually take a joke.

Oh I don't know Mr. W, I was really hoping to play cowbell on it….or maybe…triangle?

Get out of here kid! You're going to miss your bus!

I triumphantly popped my second-to-last Tic Tac into my mouth and strolled out of the room, whistling "Cubano Be, Cubano Bop."

My temporary good cheer lasted until I got on the bus. Renee Albert caught my eye (well, OK, she always catches my eye), and spoke:

How's the brain injury?

Which brought me back to reality really, really fast. I kept going toward the back of the bus without saying anything to Renee, and sat down next to Annette. I had planned to tell her all about "Cubano Be, Cubano Bop," but now my mind was back on Jeffy.

I heard that Steven. It's really cool that you were confident enough to just ignore her.

Ignore her? I didn't ignore her, I was just too stupid to think of a comeback. And now I'm going to go home and find out what happened with my brother and how long I'LL be qrounded for making breakfast.

What?

Long story. When Jeffy fell this morning I was making him oatmeal. I had him up on the stool, and my mom thinks he shouldn't be on there unless someone is like an inch and a half away. I thought I was being NICE by making him what he wanted while the rents were SLEEPING. I'm going to get maimed.

Well, your mom was right in a way.

What do you mean?

He DID fall, right?

Thanks Annette. Thanks a Lot. That's exactly what I needed to hear right now. You're a very inspiring person, you know that?

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I was just trying to…

Trying to what? Show me what a horrible brother I am?

I didn't mean to make you. . .

Feel bad? Well, you did. I've been worrying about it all day!

By this point, we were pulling up to my stop. I got up to storm off the bus, but had to wait while Renee got her stuff together in the middle of the aisle. Plus, Renee took her time walking off, too, so I had to plod along behind her. It's hard to storm and shuffle at the same time, let me tell you.

When I got off the bus, I watched Renee walk - no, glide - away. Then I looked up at Annette as the bus started to move. Maybe it was the slanted fall sun glaring off the window, but it almost looked like she was crying.

Great.

I let myself into my house and found my mom standing in the foyer, like she had been waiting for me. When I might be in trouble, I usually try to speak first, before the 'rents start in on me. So I plunged right in. *Mom, I've been worried all day. Is Jeffrey okay?*

She said, in this strange, soft voice: *Steven, your brother is really sick.*

Sick? Was it because he. ..?

The fall this morning had nothing to do with it.

Whew! **I'm** off the hook.

But he's really. . .sick.

And this was the absolute worst thing about last October 7th, the one moment I'll never forgive myself for. When my mother began to tell me that my baby brother had leukemia, my first feeling was relief.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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